JUSTIN THOMAS STEC

Center for Possible Minds, Indiana University Bloomington

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AOS: Continental philosophy; philosophy of literature; poetry and poetics; narratology
AOC: Philosophy of mind and embodied cognition; history of philosophy

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

Postdoctoral Research Associate, *Center for Possible Minds*, College of Arts & Sciences, Indiana University Bloomington, 2025–Present

Postdoctoral Research Associate, College of Arts & Sciences, University of Virginia, and Irby-Cauthen Fellow, Jefferson Scholars Foundation; Instructor, *Engagements Curriculum*, 2024–2025

EDUCATION

Ph.D., English, University of Virginia, 2024

- **Dissertation**: "Cognitive-Affective Formalism: T. S. Eliot and the Embodiment of Early Modern Verse"; Stephen Cushman (dir.), Rebecca Rush, Brad Pasanek

M.A., English, University of Virginia, 2021

B.S., Biochemistry, Duquesne University, 2016

B.A., English, Duquesne University, 2016

LANGUAGES

Latin (reading proficiency); French (reading proficiency)

PUBLICATIONS

Peer-Reviewed Articles

"Ontology After the Accident: Derrida, Malabou, and the Future of the Trace." *Derrida Today* 19.3 (forthcoming, October 2026): 277–299. https://doi.org/10.3366/drt.2026.0421

Accepted

"Khôra as *Aneu Hylēs* in T. S. Eliot and Contemporary Morphogenesis" (with Jacob Gates Foster). Proposal accepted for *Angelaki* 33.5, special issue on *khôra*, eds. Nicholas Birns and Marina Christodoulou; manuscript due March 2028.

Under Review

"On Individuation and Impersonality." Under review at *Phenomenology and the Cognitive Sciences* (submitted October 2026).

"The Historicity of a Metrical Variant: T. S. Eliot and Elizabethan Blank Verse." Under review at *Poetics Today*.

Articles in Preparation

"Subsistence and Objectivity after T. S. Eliot." In preparation for submission to the *European Journal of Philosophy*.

"On the Possibility of Poetry." In preparation for *Philosophy and Literature*.

Conceptual and modeling paper on instructional metaphor and the acquisition of tacit skill (with the Abstraction and Analogy Group, Diverse Intelligences Summer Institute). In preparation for *Philosophy and the Mind Sciences*; submission targeted for December 2026.

Book Reviews

"Building a Biographic Formalism: A Review of Jasmine Jagger's *Rhythms of Feeling in Edward Lear, T. S. Eliot, and Stevie Smith*." *The T. S. Eliot Studies Annual* 6 (2024): 201–207.

RESEARCH PROJECTS AND WORKSHOPS

"The Automation of Critical Analysis" — Scaling Mathematical Folklore

Division of Applied Mathematics, Brown University (Govind Menon) | Fall 2026

Mentor to a team of seniors in "The Automation of Critical Analysis," a focus area of Govind Menon's independent study "Scaling Mathematical Folklore," in which students read Derrida and Eliot with the help of AI tools to ask, in Menon's words, "What exactly defines taste?"

Enacting Likeness: Metaphor and the Acquisition of Tacit Knowledge

Abstraction and Analogy Group, Diverse Intelligences Summer Institute | June 2026–present

Led a five-person group (with researchers at the University of Texas at Austin, the University of Pittsburgh, Macquarie University, and the University of California, Merced) modeling metaphorical instruction as a constraint on bodily coordination: the teaching image enters a Gaussian graphical model as one component of a single precision matrix — baseline stiffness, anatomical structure, metaphorical constraint — restricting the space of possible coordinations rather than transferring content, with relative phase as the collective order parameter. On Taijiquan motion capture (twelve performers), bilateral arm phase-locking tracks judged skill (Spearman $\rho = +0.68$); synthetic and CMU motion-capture analyses show convergence under shared metaphors, task-dependent sign flips in joint coupling, and frustration under conflicting images. Since the Institute, the group has met weekly to design a controlled study isolating what an instructional image contributes; a conceptual and modeling paper is in preparation for Philosophy and the Mind Sciences, and a Big ECCE Award application proposes a twenty-participant pilot. Methodology: jts3et.github.io/cogsci-sources-viewer/modelling.html; companion: jts3et.github.io/cogsci-sources-viewer/companion.html.

How to Read a Poem — Guided-Reading Workshop and Tool

Diverse Intelligences Summer Institute | June–July 2026

Interactive workshop site and guided-reading tool built for the Diverse Intelligences Summer Institute: live collective scansion exercises whose disagreements land on a shared board; versification instruction covering meter, form, and genre from Homer to free verse; meter as the shape of the breath; and a collaborative full reading of *The Waste Land*. The Discernment Research Collaborative's Templeton proposal, "Renewing Common Culture" (under review), adapts the tool as its intervention. Site: jts3et.github.io/how-to-read-a-poem.

Metamodality Reading Group — "An Inquiry into Forms of the Possible"

Center for Possible Minds, Indiana University Bloomington | Spring 2026

Curriculum traces the concept of the possible across philosophical traditions, from Parmenides and Aristotle through Avicenna, Leibniz, Kant, and Whitehead to contemporary modal logic. Site: justinstec.github.io/metamodality.

TEACHING

Average teaching evaluation: 4.61/5.0 (2019–2025)

Instructor of Record, University of Virginia

- Food as Art?: Engaging All Five Senses (EGMT 1510), 2024–2025: First-year general education seminar in UVA's Engagements Curriculum on aesthetics and sensory theory, with experiential components including mindfulness workshops and menu design
- Literary Form and the Philosophical Imagination (ENGL 2150), 2022: Interdisciplinary seminar on the relationship between literary and philosophical form, including dialogue, lyric, and narrative modes
- Self-Writing Across Genre and Media (ENWR 1510), 2019–2020: First-year writing course exploring identity, rhetoric, and multimodal composition through autofiction, podcasting, and autoethnography

Teaching Assistant, University of Virginia

- Shakespeare: Histories and Comedies, 2021: Led discussion sections on *Richard II*, *Henry IV Parts 1 and 2*, *Henry V*, and *The Merry Wives of Windsor*. Integrated digital tools, including Folger Digital Texts and performance databases. Designed assignments on textual variants and adaptation theory
- History of Literatures in English II, 2021: Assisted in survey covering British literature 1700–present, including units on Romantic poetry (Blake, Wordsworth, Keats), Victorian novels (Austen, Dickens, G. Eliot), and Modernist experiments (Woolf, Joyce, T. S. Eliot)
- History of Literatures in English I, 2020: Supported instruction on medieval and early modern British literature, including *Beowulf*, Chaucer's *Canterbury Tales*, Spenser's *Faerie Queene*, Shakespeare's sonnets, and metaphysical poetry (Donne, Herbert, Marvell)

PRESENTATIONS

"On Ingression: Form, Pattern, and the Possible," invited video lecture, hosted by Michael Levin, 2026 (forthcoming)

"T. S. Eliot's Impersonal Theory of Emotion," CogLunch Seminar, Cognitive Science Program, Indiana University Bloomington, January 2026

"AI, Poetry, and the Limits of 'General Intelligence,'" Jefferson Fellows' Symposium Series, The Jefferson Scholars Foundation, Charlottesville, Virginia, February 2025

"The Epistolary Tradition and the Transmutation of Personal Feeling in the Emily Hale Archive," MLA Convention, Philadelphia, PA (accepted; not presented), January 2024

"The Dramatized Lyric: A Rhetorical Poetics of Shakespearean Character Speech in 'A Game of Chess,'" T. S. Eliot Society Annual Meeting, Harvard University, September 2023

"Sweeney Amongst the Philistines: Counterpoint and Sprung Rhythms in *Sweeney* and *Samson Agonistes*," ALCWS Conference, Yale University, October 2022

"'I is Nothing in Itself': Reading Karl Ove Knausgaard's *Seasonal Quartet* Through Indigenous Ontologies," ISSN Conference, New Orleans, LA, March 2020

"Narrative Catalysis: Reading Skeuomorphism in Chaucer's *The House of Fame*," University of Virginia, GradCon, 2019

"Spenser's Literary Kingdom: Translatio Imperii, Chaucerian Appropriation, Violence, and Marriage in *The Faerie Queene*, Book IV," XXX Annual Medieval and Renaissance Conference, University of Virginia at Wise, September 2016

GRANTS AND FELLOWSHIPS

John Templeton Foundation Grant Proposal (Principal Investigator), "Renewing Common Culture," Discernment Research Collaborative, Center for Possible Minds (co-directors: Jacob Foster, Erica Cartmill; with Matthew Martello, University of Virginia, and Indiana University's Center for Religion and the Human), 2026 (under review)

Big ECCE Award Application, Diverse Intelligences Summer Institute, "Enacting Likeness: Metaphor and the Acquisition of Tacit Knowledge" ($29,900; Abstraction and Analogy Group, which I led), 2026 (submitted)

Fellow, Diverse Intelligences Summer Institute, June–July 2026

Mellon Foundation Grant Application, "Narrativizing the Life After" (PIs: Phil Ford, Jacob Foster), 2025 (pending)
Irby-Cauthen Fellow, Jefferson Scholars Foundation, 2023–2025
Tuition Scholarship, International T. S. Eliot Summer School, 2022
Summer Research Grant, University of Virginia, 2022
Bradley Fellow Research Grant, University of Virginia, 2021
tranSci Resident, Department of Chemistry, University of Virginia, 2020–2021
Interdisciplinary Aesthetics Working Group Fellow, University of Virginia, 2019–2022
Travel and Conference Funding, University of Virginia, 2019

AWARDS AND HONORS

Tuition Sponsorship, Cornell School of Criticism and Theory, 2021
O'Donnell Research Award, Duquesne University, 2016
Frances J. Chivers Scholarship (Best Essay), Duquesne University, 2015, 2016

SERVICE

Regional Reader, Jefferson Scholarship Nominations, 2023–2024
Reader of Abstracts, British Women Writers Association Conference, 2023
Budget Committee Chair, UVA Graduate Conference, 2020

MENTORING AND COMMUNITY-BASED TEACHING

Founder and Mentor, "AI and Poeticity" Working Group, Jefferson Scholars Foundation, Charlottesville, Virginia, 2024–2025

Writing Center Tutor, University of Virginia, 2019–2022
Curriculum Developer, YWCA of Greater Pittsburgh, 2017–2018
Lead Science Writer, Health & Informatics Group, University of Pittsburgh, 2017–2019

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

Modern Language Association
Modernist Studies Association
International T. S. Eliot Society
International Society for the Study of Narrative